



Vote Welsh Conservative for a change

Foreword

“We are the party of change, optimism and hope”

The Conservative Party has changed. Today, we represent the working people of Wales and Britain. We are committed to improving the quality of life for everyone in our country – not just the few.

This manifesto sets out how Welsh Conservatives will improve the quality of life for everyone in Wales. Our policies are made in Wales, for Wales. Better hospitals, better schools, more affordable homes, a more sustainable environment.

But quality of life means more than good public services and a sustainable environment. It means strong families and healthy communities.

Here, society itself has a part to play. Conservatives believe that we’re all in this together – that we will only improve the quality of life in our neighbourhoods if we each live up to our social responsibilities.

That means parents taking responsibility for their children. Neighbours looking out for each other. Businesses and households conserving precious energy. Everyone taking part in local democracy, so that the decisions which affect the community have the whole community’s endorsement. All of us working together to make Wales and Britain stronger.

This is very different from the approach which Labour takes. Their response to every social problem is a state solution – a one-size-fits-all policy designed in London or Cardiff.

The Conservative Party is committed to devolution in Wales. But we need to do more. We need to devolve decision-making even further, so that local communities can have a greater say over what happens in their area.

Most of all, we need social solutions to social problems – recognising the role that independent organisations, charities and social enterprises can play in tackling some of the most profound challenges of our times.

We are determined to support families with more flexible childcare. And we will reform care for the elderly so that

looking after an elderly relative becomes more manageable.

We will protect the environment of Wales. Our amazing natural heritage is threatened by climate change, by an agricultural policy that enforces bad farming practices, and by the neglect of our coasts. We must put the environment at the heart of policy making in Wales.

The Welsh Conservative Party is committed to making Wales more green, more local, more family friendly.

For too long, Wales has been taken for granted by a single party, Labour. As a result – and despite millions of pounds of Welsh taxpayers’ money – little seems to change.

It doesn’t have to be this way. There is an alternative to Labour. Wales does not have to put up with more of the same.

On May 3, vote Welsh Conservative for a change.



David Cameron MP, Leader of the Conservative Party



Nick Bourne AM, Leader of the Welsh Conservative Party in the National Assembly



Cheryl Gillan MP, Shadow Secretary of State for Wales

Sound Finances

Stability is the bedrock of economic success. We cannot have stability without sound money and a tight grip on public spending. Welsh Conservatives would spend the same as Labour overall on public services, but we would spend the Assembly's block grant more effectively. All the spending commitments in this manifesto would be financed from an investment fund generated by reallocating 1% of existing Welsh Assembly Government budgets. A separate document has been produced to set out our spending priorities and how they would be financed.

Looking after
each other



The NHS is our priority. Welsh Conservatives want to provide a first class NHS, free to all. We are committed to improving the NHS for everyone, rather than helping the few opt out. And we are committed to the NHS ideal, ruling out any move towards an insurance-based system.

We have a vision for the NHS and healthcare in Wales which trusts doctors and nurses. Professional responsibility, not state control, guides our thinking and approach. Professionals, not politicians, should be in the driving seat so that they can decide what is best for their patients.

During our consultation with patients and care professionals all over Wales it was clear what best practice in health and social care meant:

- local GP services available when you need them;
- safe and speedy access to hospital services which should be local wherever possible;
- help when needed to remain independent, at work and at home;
- an end to long waiting lists;
- access to the modern medicines that doctors want to prescribe;
- effective services for looked after children.

Patient Care

When we are unwell we all want to be treated quickly and safely. And those of us who need help at home still want to live as independently as possible. Today, more is possible than ever before to promote our health and wellbeing. Government alone cannot achieve better health. We all have a part to play, from looking after ourselves by leading healthier lives, to having our voice heard when major changes to local services are considered.

A Welsh Conservative Government would:

- ensure that patients are treated promptly and safely throughout Wales;
- improve access to modern medicines by investing an additional £20 million each year in the drugs budget financed by our investment fund;

- use finances from our investment fund to improve cancer services, especially through access to modern drugs;
- work with hospitals to improve nutrition and provide appetising food and clean wards;
- promote independent living at home by reducing inappropriate admissions to hospital and expanding the direct payments scheme which allows people to control their own care budgets;
- publish a strategy to reduce the level of obesity in Wales and tackle diet-related ill health;
- invest an additional £10 million each year from our investment fund to produce a comprehensive palliative care strategy which would provide up to 50% of core funding for hospices and expand the role of GPs and specialist nurses in palliative care at home;
- review the dental contract to ensure better access to an NHS dentist; we would invest finance from our investment fund in orthodontic services to guarantee NHS treatment for children;
- modernise the ambulance service (including support for the air ambulance);
- pilot a nurse led walk-in centre in North Wales;
- fully utilise the skills of pharmacists, particularly in chronic disease management;
- review the provision of maternity services to further improve standards and build on the success of midwife led services.

MENTAL HEALTH REFORM

About one person in four will experience a mental illness at some time in life. Unfortunately, despite pockets of good practice, mental health services need urgent attention. Mental health law is based on 25 year old legislation which now needs reforming in line with modern practices. We would seek an Order in Council from Westminster to allow the Assembly to pass a Mental Health Reform Measure. At the heart of this reform would be the principle of the early availability of clinically appropriate treatment with coercion used only as a last resort. We need to achieve a balance between therapeutic benefit and safety of the patient with protection of the public. Patients need to be encouraged to present early and to be supported in secure settings where necessary.

Hospitals for the 21st Century

New Structures

The NHS should not be a political football. Welsh Conservatives believe that change and development should proceed on the basis of consensus. The current structure of acute services, mostly based in district general hospitals, has served Wales well. However, advances in medicine and greater specialisation make new ways of working necessary. In 2003 Sir Derek Wanless told the Assembly that a political consensus was needed to agree a way forward. Regrettably, the Labour Welsh Assembly Government has largely ignored Sir Derek's advice and pushed ahead with its own scheme, often in the face of considerable public opposition.

Welsh Conservatives would heed the advice to seek a consensus by establishing a special commission to examine the structure of hospital services. Each political party would be asked to nominate a commissioner, as would key stakeholder groups such as the BMA, RCN, patients and carers, and Community Health Councils.

Better Services

We would improve hospital services through a series of actions to:

- use the capital budget to develop intermediate care through the network of community hospitals in Wales;
- fully fund the Children's Hospital for Wales, using money from our investment fund;
- encourage NHS Trusts to seek Foundation Hospital status and allow a measure of financial autonomy to such Trusts;
- review the delivery of health services in rural areas to ensure the highest level of access to modern services;
- encourage the provision of advanced and integrated clinics in each NHS Trust for the treatment of stroke and diabetes.

A Seamless Service

The time has come to end the so-called 'Berlin Wall' between health and social care. We believe that Unified

Care Agencies offer the best way forward. These Agencies would be:

- based on local authority areas to provide primary and community health care and adult social care;
- funded by a ring-fenced grant from local authorities;
- accountable to the local authority, but at arms-length in operational matters.

We would replace the existing 22 Local Health Boards with an all-Wales commissioning body, which would develop secondary and tertiary health services.

GP practices would once again play a direct role in the commissioning of secondary services.

We would review the operation of cross-border working between NHS organisations in Wales and England.

Recognising Staff and Carers

Doctors, nurses and therapists are the life-blood of the NHS. And without the dedication of thousands of unpaid carers – usually family or friends of patients – our health services would not be able to work effectively at all.

Welsh Conservatives would support staff and carers through a series of initiatives to:

- establish carers 'contracts' financed by our investment fund, to support those delivering a substantial amount of care, including young carers. The right to respite care would be at the centre of the contract;
- require information on any assault on health staff to be sent to the CPS;
- ensure that the contract for non-consultant grade hospital doctors reflects the true contribution of these valuable professionals.

Social Care – Driving up Standards

Unified Care Agencies will help to integrate social and

TEAMWORK FOR THE VOLUNTARY SECTOR

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to help the voluntary sector flourish. The voluntary sector is key to promoting greater social justice and responsibility. Our policies would encourage teamwork in all parts of government to:

- use the voluntary sector more extensively in the planning and delivery of public services;
- place funding for the voluntary sector on a more secure footing by encouraging a 3 year-budgetary cycle;
- develop the voluntary sector scheme so that the Welsh

Assembly Government remains in close contact with the voluntary sector;

- promote a close working relationship between the voluntary sector and the National Assembly.



LOOKED AFTER CHILDREN

A Welsh Conservative Government would clearly set out in an Assembly Measure our obligations to looked after children. The principal aims of such a Measure would be to:

- promote the right to independent advocacy for looked after children, provided by a central all-Wales organisation, rather than by local authorities;
- work to raise the educational attainment of looked after children;
- promote access to training or further education for looked after children and care leavers;
- give local authorities powers to support care leavers in early adulthood;
- clarify procedures to protect 'whistleblowers'.

health care staff. This will have implications for the inspection of health and social services. Welsh Conservatives would create a single inspection body to replace the Care Standards Inspectorate for Wales and Healthcare Inspectorate for Wales. Care agencies would receive a comprehensive inspection every four years.

Social workers underpin effective social care. Welsh Conservatives would:

- provide funding out of our investment fund for the recruitment of more social workers with priority given to Children's Services;
- review the working conditions of social workers and examine the feasibility of a national contract; establish a new grade of Social Worker Consultant to retain senior social workers in practice;
- improve the quality of social care data to allow more effective performance management.

It is clear that standards in social care need to be improved across the range of services. However, Welsh Conservatives would give particular priority to the following:

- services for people with learning difficulties, especially the final stage of the resettlement programme, and we would emphasise the need for purposeful activity or, ideally, employment;
- mental health services, especially supported employment or training, and access to education and suitable housing;
- the need for vulnerable groups to access the health service to ensure that their general wellbeing is protected

– this is particularly important for people with learning disabilities or with mental illness who can become 'hidden' beneath their diagnostic labels.

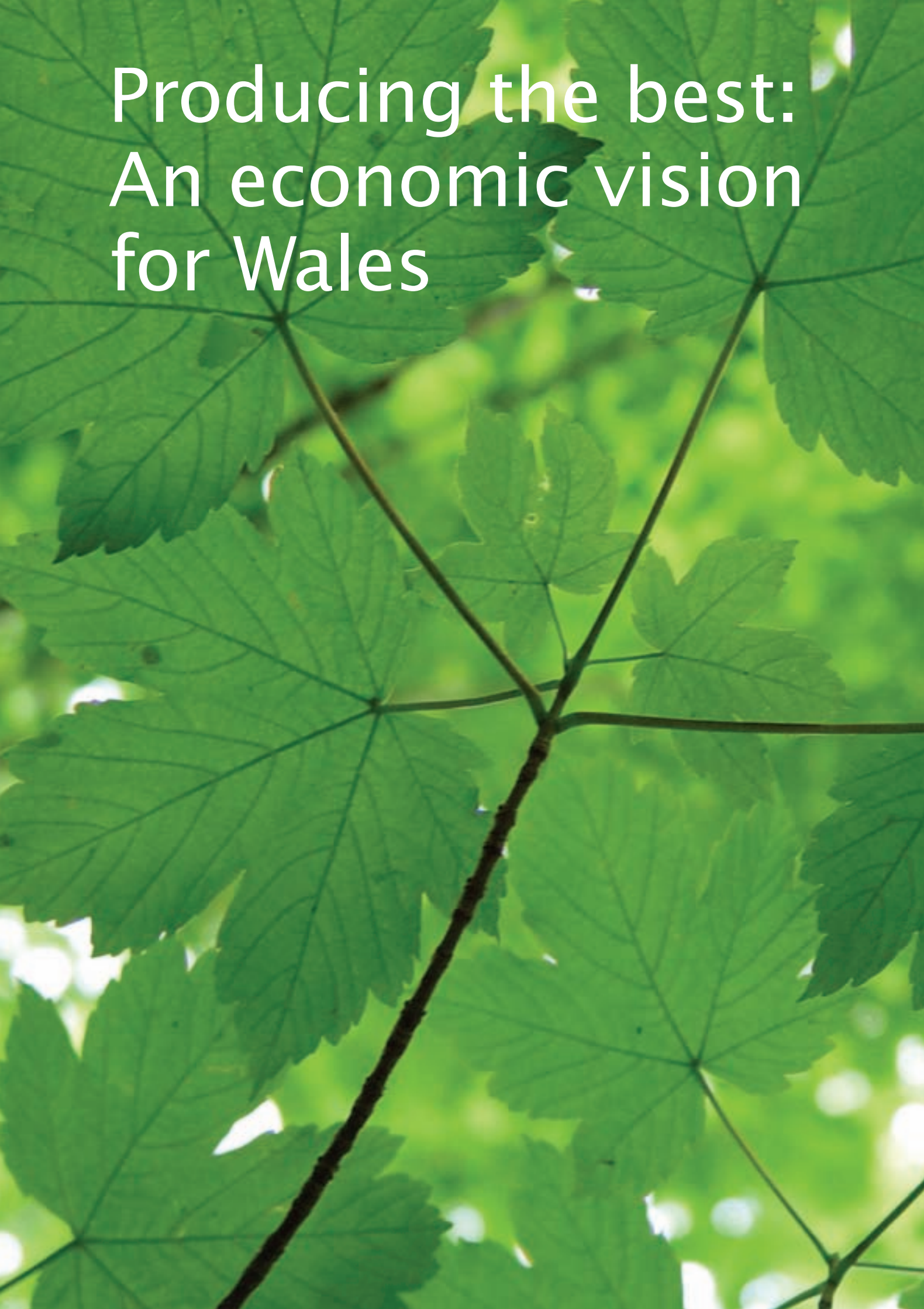
Looked After Children

We know from the Joint Reviews of social service authorities that the general standard of children's services has been inadequate, and in some cases dangerous. Under our plans to create Unified Care Agencies, the direct provision of adult social services will no longer remain the operational concern of local authorities. This will create an opportunity for local authorities to focus on their corporate parenting role. We would expect local authorities to pay particular attention to the need to drive up the level of educational attainment amongst looked after children.

The Voluntary and Independent Sectors

Government should not crowd out the voluntary and independent sectors from providing social care and health services. Each sector has a role to play. Health and social care commissioners should do more to nurture the voluntary and independent sectors and ensure that contracts and fee levels are fair and sustainable. We would expect commissioners to:

- negotiate three-year contracts in most cases and fully involve voluntary and independent providers in the planning of services;
- recognise the evidence base that is now available on the costs of providing nursing and residential care.



Producing the best: An economic vision for Wales

A stable and enterprising economy is the basis of a strong, caring society. Wales is an integral part of the British economy, but there is much scope for 'made in Wales' policies. That is what successful devolution is all about. The Welsh Conservative Party has a clear vision for our economy. We have listened to business people the length and breadth of Wales. We aim to deliver:

- a larger private sector;
- more Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs);
- a world class skills base;
- co-operation between the public and private sectors;
- greater productivity;
- secure jobs.

Enterprise – The Spirit of Success

The challenges posed by globalisation cannot be ignored, but they should not be exaggerated. New opportunities exist that were previously undreamt of and cover fields as diverse as IT and fine food and drink, to more traditional products. Welsh Conservatives believe that at heart Wales is an enterprising nation. We need a Welsh Assembly

Government that helps enterprise to flourish in local communities throughout Wales.

Operating aids can help the private sector in the search for new products and markets. A Welsh Conservative government would use our investment fund to:

- increase the amount of matched funding available for Research and Development investment;
- provide more relief for skills and training expenditure.

We would also reform Regional Selective Assistance to make it a more flexible mechanism with a greater focus on the knowledge economy and the Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) sector.

Inward Investment

While it is crucial that Welsh SMEs are encouraged to grow, the need to attract larger scale investment from outside Wales must not be overlooked. Wales was a world beater under the Conservative governments of the 1980s and 1990s in attracting inward investment. Recently, the Ministry of Defence announced that the Defence Training Academy will be based at St. Athan. Welsh Conservatives – at Westminster, in the National Assembly, and the Vale of



Promoting Entrepreneurship and Enterprise

Welsh Conservatives would introduce an Assembly Measure to promote and reward enterprise. This Measure would be the first step towards making Wales the most business friendly location in Europe. Small and medium sized businesses would be rewarded for:

- meeting energy conservation targets;
- reducing use of motor vehicles;
- allowing flexible working, e.g. for people with caring responsibilities;
- providing childcare.

Key to this reform would be an expanded business rate relief scheme financed through our investment fund. Small businesses, post offices and pubs would benefit throughout Wales. The qualifying limits for the scheme would be:

- Rateable value up to £5,000 – 50% relief;
- Rateable value between £5,000-£6,000 – 25% relief.

The scheme would allow for tapered relief between £6,000-£12,000 rateable value.

Cutting red tape. The Welsh Assembly Government would be required to review all European regulations that it can adapt or influence to lighten the regulatory burden on business. The same procedure would apply to all Welsh Assembly Government legislation.

Glamorgan Council – fully backed the Metrix bid. It showed what ‘Team Wales’ can achieve when working together.

Welsh Conservatives would ensure that Wales once again becomes one of the most competitive locations in Europe for large scale investments.

Broadband

While broadband technology is now available in most of Wales, support is needed for software and content development in order to maximise our economic opportunities. Using the existing network and developing an enhanced network in the future, is important for economic development and will be the core focus of our ICT policy.

Cohesion Funding: Creating Wealth in West Wales and the Valleys

Welsh Conservatives believe that the private sector must become the driving force behind a successful cohesion funding programme. The SME sector in particular must be expanded if long-term development and wealth creation is to be achieved. Welsh Conservatives would:

- ensure that more funds are allocated on an area basis;
- require local partnerships to demonstrate the active involvement of the private sector;
- provide operating aids to assist business start-ups;
- establish packages of pre-matched funding for projects aimed at wealth creation.

The Public Sector – A Vital Partner

Welsh Conservatives believe that there is no reason to divide the public sector from the private and voluntary sectors. Social responsibility recognises that all sectors have a role to play in tackling the problems we face. There needs to be much more co-operation between the sectors so that their respective skills and expertise can be fully utilised in the economy.

Welsh Conservatives would:

- encourage the commissioning of more public services from the private sector. We would establish a strategy

setting out the way to achieve greater partnership between the public and private sectors;

- ensure that more Welsh companies tender for public contracts, and aim for 60% or more of procurement to be Welsh based (subject to EU regulations);
- publish data on public contracts and successful tenders;
- standardise the tendering process;
- encourage local authorities to co-operate with the business sector to establish Business Improvement Districts;
- amend legislation to require Environmental Impact Assessments to be commissioned by local authorities and not developers;
- issue guidance on the provision of starter rental units on new business developments.

Social Enterprise – A Path to Prosperity

Social enterprise can empower key groups such as disabled people and the economically inactive. Welsh Conservatives embrace the co-operative ethos. We believe that local people working in partnership can transform people’s lives and their communities. Welsh Conservatives would:

- establish a grant scheme financed by our investment fund to enable joint ventures to develop between the private sector and social enterprises;
- encourage the growth of credit unions;
- increase the number of social enterprises in Wales, especially in the Cohesion areas.

Advice, Training and Development – Helping Businesses to Grow

The Business Eye initiative has had some solid success as a ‘signposter’ but it needs a more devolved mechanism that places the power of commissioning with local businesses. Welsh Conservatives would seek to strengthen the existing business advice networks and:

- improve the commissioning process for courses to develop the management skills of the indigenous business sector;
- introduce a voucher scheme to give local businesses the power to commission directly the business advice

TEAMWORK FOR MORE CHILDCARE

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to improve access to childcare. Parents across Wales need greater access to affordable, high quality childcare. Welsh Conservatives would:

- introduce incentives for employers to provide flexible working times for parents and carers, and new childcare facilities;
 - encourage the development of after-school clubs and other forms of supervised activity;
 - emphasise the provision of high quality childcare as part of the strategy to eradicate child poverty;
 - review the provision of childcare in the public sector.
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- services they need;
- encourage local authorities to develop the local market in advice and support services;
- provide a grant scheme financed by our investment fund to encourage the Further and Higher Education sectors to form partnerships with private sector companies;
- introduce an accredited 'enterprise broker' scheme for professionals – such as accountants, solicitors, and surveyors – who want to provide advice and support services to local businesses.

Transport – A Sustainable Network

A modern communications network requires a careful balance between the different modes of transport and, above all, depends upon greater integration between rail, road, air and other forms of transport. Public transport plays a vital part in any transport strategy and the Welsh Conservative Party believes that its role should be expanded. The environmental costs of transport are a matter of great public concern and must inform the choices individuals, companies and government now make. Welsh Conservatives would:

- encourage local authorities and the private sector to develop or expand car sharing schemes and 'park and ride' facilities;
- improve commuter rail services through investment in rolling stock, station improvement, new signalling technology, and passing loops, to be funded by the Cohesion programme;
- offer grant support financed by our investment fund to local authorities to introduce integrated public transport passes to allow people to utilise buses, trains, and community transport;
- seek to establish a sustainable travel demonstration town or city in Wales to increase levels of walking and cycling;
- set the following priorities for the road building programme:

- the improvement of the A470 through the provision of passing points and by-passes;
- a modern link road to Cardiff International Airport;
- the dualling of the A40 to Fishguard;
- work with Cardiff International Airport to increase the number of routes to Europe's principal commercial centres, such as Brussels, Frankfurt, Milan and Barcelona.

Tourism – Making the Most of Wales

Wales is one of the most beautiful countries in Europe, but still far too few tourists are aware of our unique attractions. Ambitious marketing is the key to increasing the number of visitors to Wales. Welsh Conservatives would:

- ensure that the Welsh Assembly Government's tourism budget promotes a long-term marketing strategy linked to key attractions such as Wales as a location for walking holidays and adventure sports;
- launch a Green Dragon marque for tourist facilities that meet sustainable development objectives;
- highlight the cultural attractions of Wales such as Eisteddfodau and the uniqueness of the Welsh language, the Victorian architecture of Cardiff, and medieval Wales and its castles;
- promote the voluntary bed and breakfast accreditation scheme. Participants would receive free marketing in a variety of official publications;
- reject all forms of tourist taxes such as a bed tax.

Science

We would establish the post of Chief Scientific Officer to the Welsh Assembly Government. The first tasks of the Chief Scientific Officer would be to review the teaching of science in Welsh schools, colleges and universities, and to produce a comprehensive science strategy for the Welsh Assembly Government.

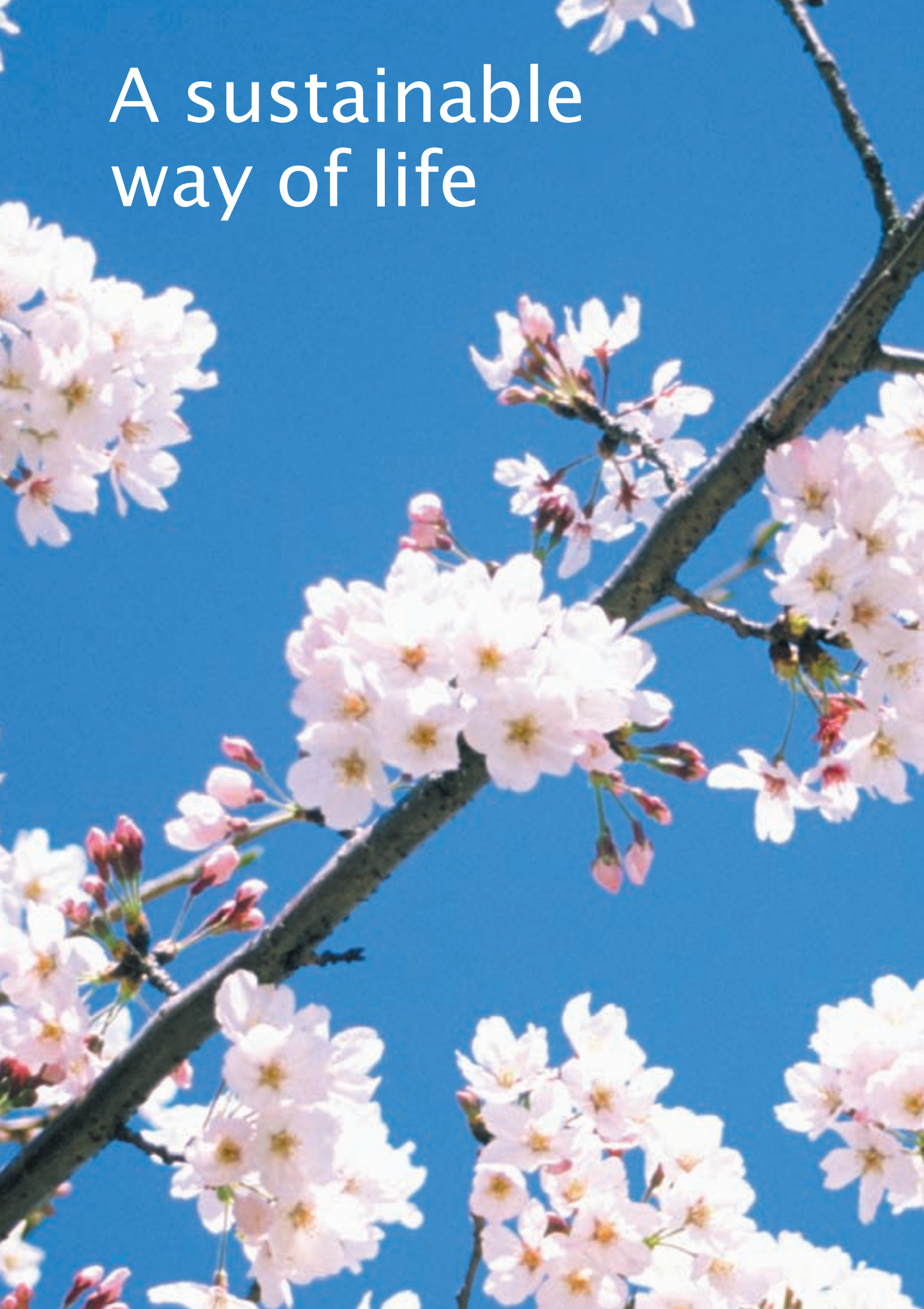


The Welsh Coastline – A Maritime Marvel

A Welsh Conservative Government would launch a seaside towns initiative to assist resorts like Tenby, Aberystwyth, Llandudno, Colwyn Bay, Porthcawl and Barry. Most of this initiative would link into the EU Cohesion Funds. The seaside towns initiative would:

- construct or renovate public amenities such as parks, piers, marine leisure facilities, hotels, theatres and other infrastructure;
- promote cultural events throughout the year, including exhibitions of art from national collections;
- revamp tourist information centres, toilets and car parks;
- encourage the growth of SMEs providing bespoke services and products such as crafts, fine foods and drink and gifts.

A sustainable
way of life



Climate change is one of the greatest challenges we face. It is set to mark the 21st century profoundly. We can – and we must – meet this challenge. We all have a role to play – government, communities, companies, and individuals. That is why a Welsh Conservative government would seek to introduce an Assembly Measure on energy so that in Wales we can set an outstanding example for other nations.

Welsh Conservatives would provide every household in Wales with £20 worth of energy saving light bulbs financed by our investment fund. Homes across the nation would receive the environmentally friendly devices in exchange for conventional incandescent bulbs in a move to cut greenhouse gas emissions.

We would support an independent body which would set annual targets to reduce emissions and monitor progress – taking the politics out of climate change.

We want to see all the green technologies come forward and play their part, but nuclear cannot be ruled out. Welsh Conservatives would be prepared to replace the Wylfa nuclear power station as part of a wide ranging policy to reduce reliance on carbon based energy.

Recycling and Waste

Far too much waste goes to landfill. We need to recycle waste more efficiently and reduce the high level of packaging that smothers so many products. Welsh Conservatives would conduct a general review of recycling in Wales to ensure that current practices are robust and do not, for example, merely result in the export of waste to developing countries. Local authorities would be required to work regionally so that waste can be managed efficiently using the latest technology. Under the Welsh Conservatives new policy priorities would be set to:

- recycle more domestic waste: at least 40% by 2011;
- for waste that cannot be recycled, move local authorities away from landfill as the option of choice to other methods such as combined heat and power incinerators;

- require the NHS and other bodies to reduce the number of ‘food miles’ generated in their procurement procedures.

Planning: Meeting Local Needs

Many people feel frustrated by the apparent lack of flexibility in the planning system. Traditionally, Britain has had one of the most restrictive and controlled planning systems in the world. While this approach has generally served us well, challenges such as the provision of affordable housing and keeping rural communities viable, must be faced. Welsh Conservatives would:

- give greater freedom to planning authorities to provide more land for affordable housing, especially in rural areas;
- set new targets for the release of land for development;
- require developers to measure the carbon footprint of developments;
- ensure that planning guidance for rural areas promotes the viability of local communities;
- review the functions of the National Park Authorities and introduce a proportion of elected members to their Boards;
- publish a Marine Spatial Plan and ensure that it is integrated with the Wales Spatial Plan where appropriate;
- examine ways to promote the efficient use of water.

Countryside – A Fair Deal for Farmers

Farmers are in the front line of protecting our environment. They also underpin rural communities. Welsh Conservatives believe that farming must be properly valued and we do not want to see large tracts of land abandoned. People all over Wales want to enjoy a well-managed countryside. Of course, farming practices will continue to change as farmers respond to the challenges of CAP reform and grapple with the forces of globalisation. But to manage change successfully, farmers must be confident that government has a coherent vision for a more prosperous rural economy. A Welsh Conservative government would:

- consult widely with farmers, their unions, and other stakeholders on ways to gain maximum benefit from the Rural Development Plan;
- ensure that any scheme for ‘modulation’ does not reduce the envelope of resources available to agriculture and that we

TEAMWORK TO REDUCE CLIMATE CHANGE

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to help reduce climate change. We all have a responsibility to take global warming seriously. And we will all benefit from a cleaner, greener environment. Welsh Conservatives would:

- introduce an Assembly Measure to develop renewable energy and promote energy efficiency;
- encourage recycling and ensure that less waste goes to landfill;
- ensure that agri-environmental support for farmers is connected to measurable outcomes such as an increase in biodiversity;
- promote schemes to improve the integration of public transport;
- encourage businesses and public services to reduce the use of motor vehicles and use local goods and services wherever possible.



ENERGY: THE POWER TO SWITCH

Wales needs a highly innovative strategy to develop renewable energy and promote energy efficiency.

Our Assembly Measure would:

- set a renewable energy target of 15% to be achieved by 2015;
- permit grant funding for renewable projects such as tidal power, bio-fuels, and hydro power;
- offer business users grant support for micro and community generation schemes as part of the business rate reform policy;
- set energy efficiency targets for the public sector;
- permit grant support for energy efficiency projects;
- devolve the planning process for renewable power generation projects over 50 MWs;
- devolve building regulations to the National Assembly.

- remain close to the EU compulsory modulation level;
- support farmers in upland and other less favoured areas by increasing the allocation of funding for the Tir Mynydd scheme;
- reduce the bureaucracy attached to the Tir Cynnal scheme. It is perverse to surround what should be a simple agri-environment entry scheme with so much red tape;
- develop a strategy for the growth of biomass crops in Wales. Biomass technology has a key part to play in the provision of more renewable energy but the current competitive disadvantage Wales suffers compared to England must be removed.

Farmers know that the public has a right to expect a range of outcomes in return for such support. Welsh Conservatives would look to enter into a partnership with farmers and the public to:

- clearly connect agri-environmental payments to measurable outcomes such as an increase of bio-diversity;
- meet high animal welfare standards;
- manage the countryside responsibly, such as maintaining footpaths.

The rural economy has undergone substantial changes in the last 30 years. Farmers and rural entrepreneurs need advice and

assistance as they compete in today's markets. Welsh Conservatives would:

- review the educational and training opportunities available to farmers, new entrants, and other employees in land-based industries. As old-style agricultural colleges become less viable, we must ensure that the Further and Higher Education sectors can meet the demand for training and development courses;
- launch a Welsh Food and Drink strategy to:
 - increase the 'value added' element in production by taking opportunities to finish products nearer the farm gate;
 - market Welsh food and drink with a special charter mark;
 - encourage the public sector to take account of 'food miles' in their procurement policies;
 - identify the range of 'niche' markets, such as fine food and organic products, for development;
 - establish a new code of conduct, if possible on a statutory basis, between supermarkets and suppliers;
 - encourage the development of meat and food processing in Wales that could also be labelled Welsh;
 - develop a strategy for the Welsh dairy sector in close consultation with the farming unions.

Welsh Conservatives want to protect and nurture the rural way of life. Welsh Conservatives would:

- act on the body of evidence regarding bovine TB. We would implement a strategy to control bovine TB and use those methods proven to be effective;
- prevent the commercial planting of GM crops until it has been verified that the technology is safe;
- in co-operation with the UK Government, strengthen security at ports and airports to prevent communicable animal diseases, such as foot-and-mouth, entering the country;
- seek a derogation from the EU to permit the burial of fallen stock in the more remote parts of Wales and continue to negotiate for on-farm disposal systems such as bio-digesters.

Young Farmers

Welsh Conservatives believe that farming has an important part to play in safeguarding sustainable rural communities. We cannot prevent change, but we can help the industry to adapt and take advantage of new opportunities. Key to this is keeping enterprising young farmers in agriculture. Welsh Conservatives would:

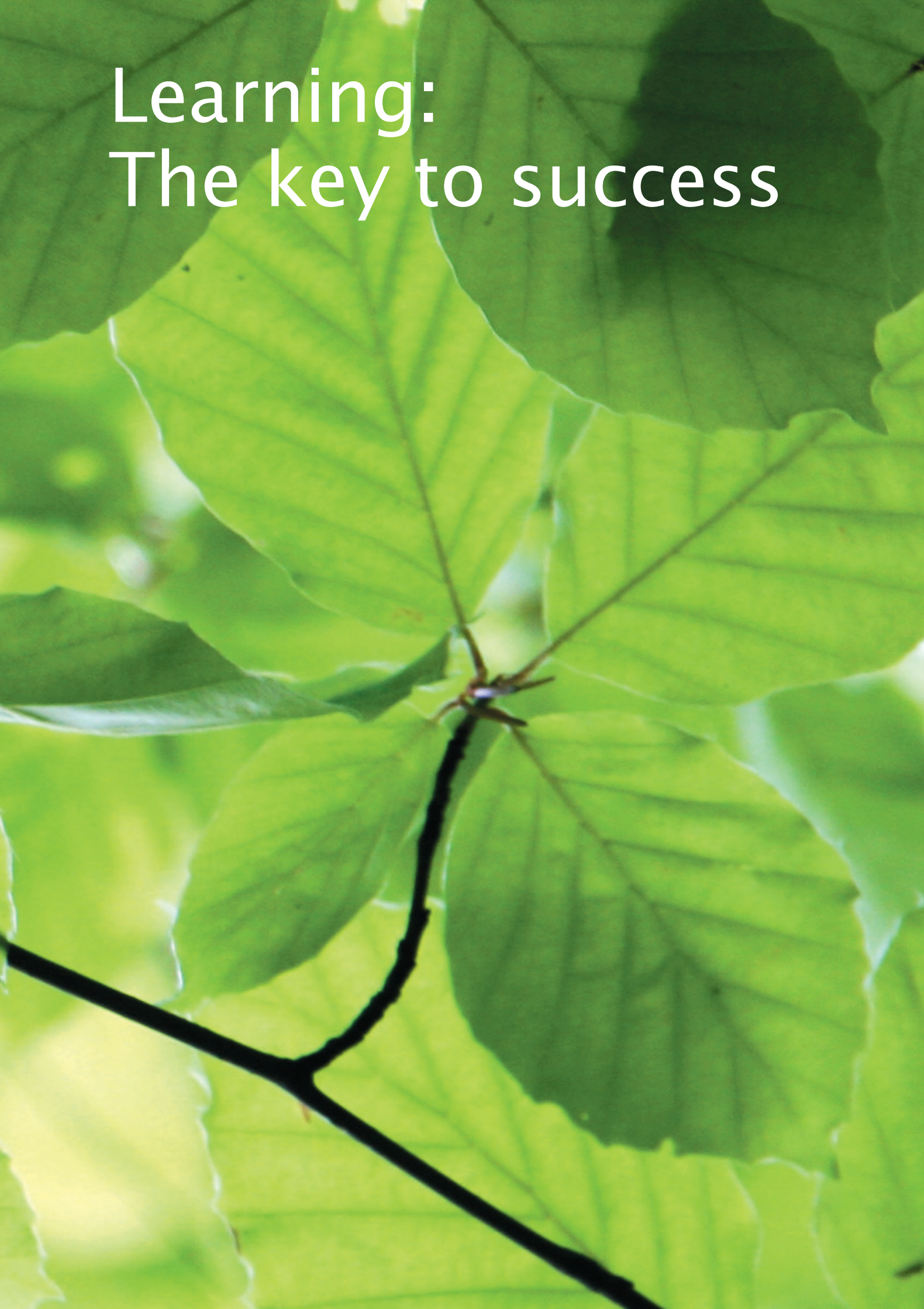
- review the provision of education and training in the agricultural sector and how it can be more effectively linked to general business advice and training;
- establish a consultative forum with the Young Farmers' Clubs network;
- create an enterprise grant scheme for young farmers entering the industry.

Biodiversity

Welsh Conservatives believe that farmers and land managers should be encouraged to maximise the biodiversity opportunities that come from sensitive land-use and the development of well-managed ecosystem services. We are committed to the goal of ending the loss of biodiversity in Wales by 2010. However, to achieve this ambitious target the Environment Strategy for Wales needs to be strengthened. Welsh Conservatives would:

- issue an annual Welsh Assembly Government statement on progress towards achieving the Environment Strategy's targets;
- require the Countryside Council for Wales to report annually on the state of Sites of Special Scientific Interest;
- prohibit development on Sites of Special Scientific Interest unless sanctioned by a vote of the National Assembly;
- work in closer co-operation with the European Commission to promote biodiversity.

Learning:
The key to success



A good education opens the door to life's opportunities. Good schools don't just teach children how to read, write and add up. A good school inspires young people to learn and follow their interests, and teaches them to be responsible adults. Welsh Conservatives would reverse the current centralised education policies of the Welsh Assembly Government. We would strike a careful balance between local choice, core national standards, and effective spending.

Schools: the Freedom to Succeed

A high proportion of school funding is top sliced by local education authorities. We believe that Welsh schools should receive their basic core funding directly from the Welsh Assembly Government and on a three year budgetary cycle. Given this financial security, schools would be able to develop innovative business plans for development.

A Welsh Conservative government would introduce a range of policies to encourage versatility, choice, and higher standards. We would:

- use our investment fund to move to close the gap between the amount spent per pupil in England and Wales by 2011;
- encourage LEAs to implement an IT strategy to make schools in Wales world leaders;
- publish a strategy on the development of Key Stage 3 education (11-14 year olds). This is an area where Wales needs rapid improvement if we are to match standards achieved in England. The current sluggish performance at Key Stage 3 has a particularly harsh effect on pupils from disadvantaged backgrounds;
- review the national curriculum to allow for greater choice and flexibility, particularly at Key Stage 4 (14-16 year olds);
- strengthen the 'A' level qualification, but allow for choice in developing a robust Welsh baccalaureate with a core element in the range of 10 to 12 hours per week, and support schools offering the International Baccalaureate;
- review Special Educational Needs policy in light of the Assembly's Education and Lifelong Learning Committee's reports; and improve the statementing process for children with Special Educational Needs;
- encourage the development of specialist schools, and support faith schools;
- allow LEAs, especially smaller LEAs, to combine and share organisational structures. LEAs should focus on their strategic 'mapping' role and the need to maintain standards;

- review the role of Estyn so that inspections become less burdensome and more directly focused on continual development. We would require Estyn to identify and publicise good practice and offer advice;
- allow community partnerships to be formed when an LEA announces its intention to close a school. Such partnerships might include community councils, local businesses, and parent groups.

Schools: a Healthy and Safe Environment

No school can be successful unless it is a healthy and safe environment in which all pupils can develop and prepare for the opportunities of adult life. Rewarding good behaviour and honest endeavour is as important as recognising academic excellence. While schools are much more than buildings, a Welsh Conservative government would address the shortfall in capital spending that has developed in Wales. We would use a proportion of education spending to introduce a scheme to match fund LEA capital spending, and we would encourage the use of other funding mechanisms such as PFI or community trusts. We would encourage new school buildings to be built according to carbon neutral criteria. Pupils and parents also have a right to expect the highest standards of safety in school buildings.

Welsh Conservatives would launch a Wellbeing Strategy with the development of the whole child at its heart. It would ensure that:

- schools are served by a strengthened network of school nurses;
- full value is given to PSE themes throughout the curriculum. Particular attention would be given to discussion of personal relationships, social responsibility, substance misuse, healthy lifestyles, and debt and financial management. Teachers would receive support and training to tackle these themes;
- a food and nutrition strategy is launched to improve the quality of school dinners and promote knowledge of food and cooking among all pupils;
- the safe routes to school initiative is developed;
- our investment fund supports the introduction of a modern school transport system based on the use of single deck buses and appropriate supervision (or CCTV) and an end to the 'three-to-a-seat' rule;
- schools are given greater freedom to meet the out-of-hours needs of pupils by abolishing the requirement to provide free school breakfasts, and focusing on activities such as after-school clubs.

There is compelling evidence that a lack of exercise is causing



A VOCATION TO EXCEL

Welsh Conservatives would fully recognise the value of vocational education and skills development. We would introduce an Assembly Measure to set new standards for vocational education which would:

- encourage 16-19 year olds not in full time education to engage in one of the following:-
- a modern apprenticeship;
- work-based training related to a recognised qualification;
- a Sector Skills Council training scheme;
- call for a vocational based curriculum for all 14-16 year olds who want it;
- establish a mechanism to allow the business sector full involvement in the development and implementation of vocational education;
- develop lifelong learning programmes for vocational education and skills development.

a disturbing increase in obesity amongst children. A greater focus needs to be placed on physical education in schools as a preparation for exercise throughout life. A greater diversity of sporting and leisure activity needs to be provided.

Supporting our Teachers

Without the dedicated work of teachers no school would succeed. More needs to be done to support teachers and give them real responsibility over their classrooms so that they can give of their best. Other groups – such as teaching assistants and school governors – need greater support. Welsh Conservatives would:

- use our investment fund to invest in a programme of professional development for teachers, teaching assistants and governors;
 - examine the feasibility of establishing a National College of School Leadership;

- establish national teacher awards and a sabbatical scheme for teachers;
- review the mechanisms surrounding child protection policies and the effectiveness of the advocacy services offered to teachers facing allegations of abuse and misconduct.

Pupils and Parents

Pupils and parents should have more involvement in how local schools are run. A Welsh Conservative government would:

- encourage schools to conduct annual pupil and parent satisfaction surveys and to publish the results;
- maintain the requirement for schools to have school councils. The operation of school councils would be reviewed, and if necessary strengthened, by 2011;

TEAMWORK FOR CHILDREN'S SERVICES

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to improve children's services. We would create a new Cabinet portfolio of Minister for Children to combine pre-18 education, children's services and

action to eradicate child poverty. Welsh Conservatives would:

- focus on reducing the number of accidental deaths and serious injuries amongst children;
- consult more widely with

children, including through pupil surveys in schools;

- introduce an Assembly Measure to improve services for looked after children;
- reform vocational education for 14-18 year olds.

- strengthen the pupil-parent contracts that schools can apply as a condition of admission and attendance;
- encourage LEAs to provide classes in parenting skills for the parents of disruptive pupils;
- publish a strategy to reduce bullying in schools;
- give headteachers greater control over discipline. And invest in services to improve the behaviour and basic skills of disruptive pupils.

Students, Colleges, Universities

Since devolution, colleges and universities in Wales have not received the support they deserve. A damaging funding gap has emerged. If Wales is to achieve economic success in a highly competitive global economy, colleges and universities require greater investment and support.

A Welsh Conservative Party motion in the Assembly stopped the introduction of top-up fees in Wales, and it demonstrates how we would imaginatively use devolution to meet the specific needs of Wales. A Welsh Conservative government would:

- rule out the introduction of top-up fees for Welsh domiciled students studying in Wales;
- invest in Higher Education, using our investment fund to move to close the funding gap that has opened up between Wales and England;
- review the implementation of comparable pay scales for FE lecturers;
- abolish the FE Common Initiative Fund and return the revenue to FE institutions;
- encourage the growth of the Research and Development sector, including HE – private sector partnerships, to add much needed vitality to the knowledge economy;
- examine ways to increase the amount of medical research undertaken in Wales;
- market FE and HE distance learning services more effectively, particularly overseas;
- make Wales a more attractive choice for non-EU students by introducing a work permit scheme;
- develop the export earning potential of the HE sector.

Lifelong Learning

The importance of lifelong learning for personal wellbeing or professional development is now well recognised. The scope of education and learning extends well beyond the school room and lecture hall. However, Wales is still far from becoming what the Welsh Assembly Government calls a Learning Country. Welsh Conservatives would:

- examine ways to expand work-based learning;
- focus on key skills and examine the recommendations of the Leitch Review;
- emphasise the importance of skills development, and the acquiring of new skills, to the Welsh economy and especially to the regeneration of the Cohesion Funding regions;
- develop a ‘citizen’s module’ for use in lifelong learning curricula;
- ensure that existing budgetary provisions are used to implement the Graham Review into fees and support for part-time HE students.

Welsh Medium Education

The success of Welsh medium education is rightly a matter in which we can all take great pride. Welsh Conservatives are committed to ensuring the continued success of Welsh medium nursery, primary and secondary education and will respond to parental demand to see it expanded. However, a concerted effort is now needed to increase the number of Further and Higher Education courses available in Welsh. Welsh Conservatives would publish a strategy to achieve this important development.

Social justice: Building a stronger society



Welsh Conservatives have a strong belief in social justice. Everyone should have good housing, a safe environment, an adequate income, and respect for their beliefs and cultures. These are the conditions which allow individuals, families, and communities to flourish. Devolution has given Wales the chance to set a world-class example by skilfully integrating policies across all spheres of government to promote regeneration and greater equality.

Housing: The Foundation of Community Life

The lack of affordable housing blights many lives. It deprives communities all over Wales because young people are forced to leave their local areas. Not enough homes are being built, and so we face stark divisions between the young – who cannot afford to buy family homes – and older people who bought before the house price boom. A Welsh Conservative government would introduce an Assembly Measure to meet this challenge.

One of our first priorities would be to publish a housing strategy that responds to the key housing challenges and that fully reflects our socially responsible approach. Welsh Conservatives would involve mortgage lenders, builders, landlords, housing associations, local authorities, tenants and other key groups in the development of our housing strategy. We would:

- inject an extra £16 million each year from our investment fund into the housing budget to increase the number of affordable houses being built, especially in rural areas;
- encourage home ownership – or part ownership – as a means to promote regeneration in the most deprived communities;
- produce an action plan setting out clearly how the Welsh Housing Quality Standards (WHQS) would be achieved;
- take the requirement to meet the WHQS as an opportunity to promote local regeneration by using local businesses and local skilled workers whenever possible;
- administer centrally the Supporting People Revenue Grant Budget.

An End to Poverty

Too often the natural spark of enterprise is suffocated in deprived communities by the problems of crime, economic inactivity, and poor skills. Unresponsive public services and overwhelming state control crowds out initiatives taken by communities themselves. While the Communities First strategy is innovative in concept, in practice little progress



HOUSING FOR ALL

The supply of housing, including affordable and social housing, would be increased by a range of policies in our Housing Measure:

- planning authorities would be required to release more land for development;
- land-owning public bodies would be asked to identify land suitable for development;
- greater flexibility would be given to planning authorities to release land contiguous with existing communities for development, where such developments would meet local housing needs;
- provision of affordable and social housing would be required in all developments over a certain size or provided for in planning gain contributions elsewhere in the local community;
- developers would be required to measure the carbon footprint of developments.

Many people who want to own their own homes need assistance to do so. Others prefer to rent, and it is amongst certain groups of tenants that some of the greatest housing challenges are found. Our Housing Measure would:

- affirm a tenant's right to buy; and extend part-ownership schemes like Homebuy;
- create a new tenancy for vulnerable groups, such as former looked after children. Supported tenancies would provide a programme of support legally linked to the tenancy;
- establish a new form of housing co-operative for people with a common interest to provide social housing for themselves. This could involve new build or the renovation of existing stock;
- create a unitary social housing tenancy.

has yet been made to transform Wales' 100 most deprived communities.

Welsh Conservatives believe that no society or economy can be considered successful while many children live in poverty. A Welsh Conservative government would publish an action plan with clear, measurable targets that would move Wales towards the goal of eradicating child poverty by 2020.

While the traditional welfare state has to a large extent ended absolute poverty, the challenge of eradicating relative poverty is perhaps more formidable. For community regeneration to be sustainable, local people must 'own' schemes and not be overwhelmed by top down policies imposed from outside. Welsh Conservatives would:

- emphasise the provision of training and skills development;
- make more effective use of the voluntary sector in creating community organisations capable of managing regeneration programmes;
- encourage the growth of social enterprises in deprived communities;
- tackle debt poverty through measures such as increasing the number of credit unions and the provision of courses in financial skills;
- review the strategy to end fuel poverty in light of the recent sharp increases in energy prices.

Safer Communities

Communities cannot thrive unless people feel safe on the streets and secure at home. Many people feel let down by the authorities as the problems of alcohol and drug abuse are not properly tackled and remain the source of much crime and anti-social behaviour. We all have a role to play in tackling these problems – families, schools, the police, and local communities. Welsh Conservatives would take practical steps to fight crime and its causes. Our priorities would be to:

- increase the number of alcohol and drug detox places, including residential care;
- create a network of local warden resource centres to tackle petty crime and anti-social behaviour;
- review drug and alcohol strategies and ensure that the specific challenges of alcohol addiction are met.

Welsh Conservatives opposed the Home Office's plans for a single police force in Wales. We believe that such a super-force would have been bureaucratic and unresponsive to local needs. However, the requirement for the Welsh forces to co-operate on strategic matters must be acknowledged, as should the need for cross-border collaboration between forces in Wales and England.

Welsh Conservatives would continue with the current three regional divisions of the Fire and Rescue Service in Wales. More flexibility in the operation of the emergency services should be encouraged subject to the necessary training and support. We would strengthen the fire rescue and prevention strategies to emphasise home safety and the provision of fire alarms and sprinkler systems in new buildings (especially schools).

Many people from the newly admitted EU states of eastern Europe have come to work in Wales. While most intend to return home and place little demand on public services, it is important that the longer term impact of such immigration is evaluated. The Welsh Conservative Party is particularly concerned that an obligation might be placed on some local authorities without the necessary financial assistance from central government. People in Wales also need to be assured that our borders are secure and that appropriate levels of security and immigration control are kept at our ports and airports. While primarily a responsibility of the UK government, Welsh Conservatives would work with the various agencies to ensure the highest possible level of border security.

TEAMWORK FOR OLDER PEOPLE

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to help older people. Without harnessing the talents of older people we cannot achieve the goal of a socially responsible society. Welsh Conservatives would:

- grant all pensioner households a £100 discount on their Council Tax bills each year;
- review the Independent Living Scheme and encourage the use of Direct Payments for older people needing care and support at home;
- move away from the concept of a compulsory retirement age;
- improve access to modern medicines;
- work closely with the Commissioner for Older People.

Promoting Equality

Welsh Conservatives believe that everyone has a right to live in dignity, seek employment and enjoy access to public services regardless of gender, race, age, religion, disability or sexual orientation. We welcome the establishment of the Commission for Equality and Human Rights which will be a single authority for equality issues. We recognise that everyone in society has a role to play in tackling discrimination. So Welsh Conservatives would expand the equalities work undertaken in local communities, often by voluntary organisations.

Welsh Conservatives would:

- review the Independent Living Scheme;
- emphasise the commitment to the social model of disability, and introduce 'equality proofing' to the policy making process of the Welsh Assembly Government;
- encourage the Commission for Equality and Human Rights to form regional partnerships with voluntary organisations – such as Race Equality Councils – to promote equality and diversity in local communities;
- include a statement on equality of access in the annual reports of public services which will be published at a national and local level;
- look at the feasibility of ending compulsory retirement in the public sector by 2011.

Welsh Conservatives supported the retention of a duty on the Welsh Assembly Government to promote equality. We believe that in the new arrangements for the Assembly after May 2007, a cross cutting equalities committee should continue to operate.

The Voluntary Sector

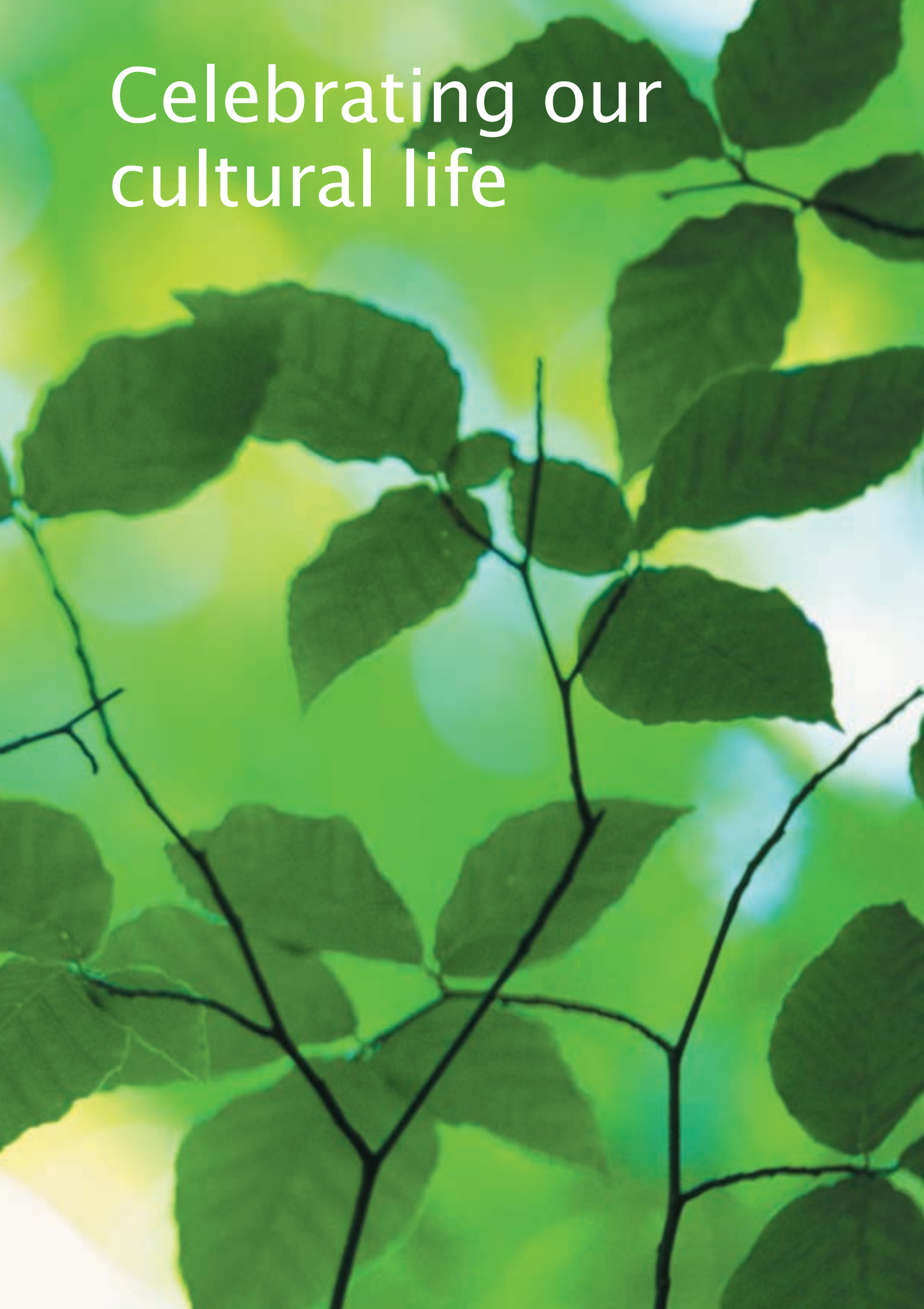
The Government of Wales Act 2006 retains the statutory requirement for a Voluntary Sector Partnership between the Welsh Assembly Government and the voluntary sector. A Welsh Conservative government would also continue to operate the Voluntary Sector Partnership Council. Welsh Conservatives would like to see more involvement from the voluntary sector in the delivery of public services. We also believe that the commissioning process should be strengthened by such measures as a three year budget cycle.

Post Offices

Welsh Conservatives want to see community Post Offices flourishing all over Wales. Post Offices are at the heart of communities and offer a range of services to local people. Many Welsh Assembly Government services and initiatives – such as economic and social regeneration – could do more to utilise the facilities of Post Offices.

Welsh Conservatives would:

- re-establish and enhance the Post Office development fund, investing £4 million in the scheme annually financed by our investment fund;
- give local Post Offices business rate relief as part of our business rate relief scheme;
- examine ways to increase the number of services available from Post Offices;
- use the Post Office development fund to set up broadband and other internet services in community Post Offices;
- set up a task force with the National Federation of Sub-Postmasters to examine ways to help our threatened Post Offices.

A close-up photograph of green leaves and branches, with the text "Celebrating our cultural life" overlaid in the top left corner. The leaves are a vibrant green, and the branches are dark and thin. The background is a soft, out-of-focus green, creating a sense of depth and natural beauty.

Celebrating our
cultural life

Welsh Conservatives celebrate our nation's cultural achievements. Our language is one of Europe's most distinguished with a literary tradition stretching back 1,400 years. The arts flourish in Wales: in Welsh and English language literature, painting and sculpture, and in the performing arts. In the National Eisteddfod, Wales has one of the biggest and most vibrant cultural events in the world. Welsh Conservatives also celebrate Welsh sporting success and we want to see it grow.

Sadly, Welsh Labour has failed to build on these successes. Labour's policies have been bossy and bureaucratic. Rather than fostering unity, Labour have helped to create unprecedented division in the cultural arena.

Welsh Language

Welsh Conservatives believe that Welsh should be given official language status and that an independent language commissioner should be created. Partly as a result of Conservative policies between 1979-97, the number of Welsh speakers has increased for the first time since 1891, according to the 2001 census. But this is the start of a long journey and not its triumphant conclusion. We need to take another bold step and commit ourselves to the goal of creating a truly bilingual nation. A Welsh Conservative government would establish a language recovery unit to examine the international evidence in this area.

The National Eisteddfod and the International Eisteddfod are among the biggest cultural events held anywhere in Europe. And the Urdd Eisteddfod is a wonderful celebration of youth culture. Welsh Conservatives believe that these iconic cultural celebrations should receive reliable financial support from the Welsh Assembly Government so that the opportunities for tourism, education, and economic regeneration are fully grasped.



Broadcasting and Film Production

A Welsh Conservative government would review the Creative Industries Strategy to:

- attract more film and TV production work to Wales, taking greater advantage of the London-based market;
- examine the feasibility of opening a National Film and TV School as part of a general review of education and training in media and creative industries;
- take full advantage of the opportunities created by the Cohesion funding programme.

A New Vision for the Arts

The Clos Stephens Report has led to the reversal of the Welsh Assembly Government's disastrous decision to politicise the arts. Welsh Conservatives believe that for vitality and innovation to be encouraged in our cultural life, the Arts Council of Wales must operate under the security of the arms-length principle. Partnerships between the Welsh Assembly Government, local authorities, and the Arts Council are vital, but they should not be overbearing. Welsh Conservatives would examine the feasibility of establishing a duty on local authorities to promote the arts. We would also like to see decision-making on the smaller grants scheme devolved to local authorities. Both the Arts Council of Wales nationally and Councils locally would be asked to use existing budgets to:

- promote policies to increase participation in the arts;
- identify ways to encourage audience sizes to grow;
- improve access to the arts for people from disadvantaged groups;
- promote artistic activity in schools.

In Wales, our vision should be to become a world class centre for the performing arts. The Royal Welsh College of Music and Drama is already leading the way in nurturing and training young performers. Many of them will one day

CREATING A BILINGUAL WALES

This Measure would accord, to both Welsh and English, official language status and also:

- create the office of Language Commissioner and set out the functions of that office;
- place a duty on the Welsh Assembly Government and local authorities and other public bodies to create a more bilingual society.

perform at the Wales Millennium Centre, a beautiful building that has already given a boost to our cultural life.

Welsh Conservatives would:

- examine the feasibility of a National Theatre for English-language drama based at Theatr Clwyd in Mold;
- publish a strategy to promote public participation in the arts, and emphasise the education, training, and economic development potential of the arts;
- establish an arts chartermark scheme for schools;
- encourage and develop professional performing arts all over Wales.

Welsh Conservatives believe that the arts can be used to illustrate the confidence and vitality of Welsh society. More should be done to market our cultural attractions, particularly abroad. Welsh Conservatives would build on the success of major events like the Artes Mundi prize, the Cardiff Singer of the World and the Dylan Thomas Prize. Awarding National Assembly medals for the arts would be part of this strategy. Welsh Conservatives would also:

- undertake the necessary planning and consultations to create a National Gallery in Cardiff, linked to a series of local galleries across Wales;
- publish a strategy on the commissioning and marketing of Welsh writing in English;
- work with the National Archives and the UK government to examine the feasibility of a National Archive at the National Library, Aberystwyth;
- examine the feasibility, with the use of EU funds, of creating a Museum of the Celtic Civilisation, which would be located in North Wales.

The magnificent St. Fagans National History Museum, the most visited attraction in Wales, demonstrates the potential of the historic environment in promoting employment, traditional arts and crafts, and education. Welsh Conservatives would:

- publish a strategy on the marketing of the Welsh historic environment and its role in key areas such as economic development, training and education;
- improve the general architectural standard of new buildings in Wales, particularly public buildings, by strengthening the powers of the Design Commission for Wales.

Libraries across Wales are enjoying a remarkable revival as information technology brings the world to the desktop. Welsh Conservatives believe that the Welsh Assembly Government should work in partnership with local authorities to take full advantage of libraries as a community resource. The design of libraries is key to this and we want to see versatile and exciting new buildings across Wales. Using libraries as exhibition spaces is just one example of how libraries can be central to our cultural life.

Sport and Leisure

Welsh Conservatives want to see greater emphasis placed on sport in schools and a general increase in sporting and leisure activities in the community. The voluntary sector is crucial to achieving a more active, sporting nation. The Welsh Assembly Government has a part to play in integrating sport into a range of policy areas such as economic regeneration and health promotion. We are also



PLAYING TO WIN

Welsh Conservatives have already strengthened the secondary legislation to protect playing fields. We would take this principle further and introduce an Assembly Measure to protect playing fields, parks and open spaces in urban areas. Local authorities would be required to audit such facilities and ensure that they are adequately provided for in new developments. Access to sporting and leisure facilities would become a central part of health and wellbeing strategies.

keenly aware of the need to ensure ‘access for all’ to sporting and leisure facilities. At the heart of our strategy for sport would be policies to:

- prepare a bid by 2011 to host the Commonwealth Games in Cardiff-Newport in 2018 or 2022;
- encourage the development of countryside pursuits and adventure sports such as walking, canoeing, climbing, riding, shooting, and fishing;
- emphasise the need to exercise for life and identify ways of improving ‘access for all’ to sporting and leisure facilities, and ensure that the needs of disabled people are addressed;
- review the elite events strategy and market Wales more aggressively as a venue. We would encourage the Football Association of Wales to bid for the UEFA cup final;
- take full advantage of the opportunities generated by Wales hosting the Ryder Cup in 2010;
- ensure that training venues in Wales are properly marketed for the 2012 Olympics;
- take full advantage of the promotion of Sophia Gardens to Test Match status in 2009 when it hosts one of the Ashes Tests;
- invest in an ‘access for all’ grant to provide funding for sporting kit and equipment, so that children and young people from low income families can more easily take up sport.

Community leaders – the role of Local Government



Welsh Conservatives believe in passing power and responsibility to local communities, businesses and families wherever possible. Trusting them is what social responsibility is all about. We want to see councils become the champions of local communities and not remain the branch offices of the Welsh Assembly Government. Our vision is bold: local government must lead the way in reforming public services, creating greater accountability, and securing more diverse participation in decision-making. A Welsh Conservative government would introduce an Assembly Measure to alter radically the balance of power between the Assembly and local councils.

The relationship between the Welsh Assembly Government and local authorities would be transformed in other ways. Welsh Conservatives believe that the burden of inspection has become unwieldy and confusing. We would simplify the inspection process and set a limited number of core standards for performance. Councils would have to deliver a good core standard in each public service area but beyond that councils would be able to determine their own priorities in response to local need.

Welsh Conservatives would also:

- introduce a three-year budgetary cycle for local government expenditure;
- set out guidance to allow more extensive use of by-law powers by local councils, e.g. over matters like anti-social behaviour;
- examine ways to strengthen the role of the Local Government Partnership Council;
- co-operate with the Welsh Local Government Association to continue the improvement of performance data and the use of comparative measures between councils.

Accountability

Welsh Conservatives would strengthen the accountability of local government in a number of ways. We would:

- review the arrangements for local government elections, with a view to possible referendums on the form of election;
- encourage the move, subject to local referendums, to elected mayors;
- strengthen the scrutiny role of councillors;
- set targets to improve the diversity of councillors.

Sir Jeremy Beecham’s useful report *Beyond Boundaries* recommends the publication of local annual reports on public services. The Welsh Conservative Party accepts this recommendation and also Sir Jeremy’s call for the publication of clear information on performance that can be readily understood by the media, public and elected councillors. This would be an example of localism in action and it would allow people a real say on how their money is spent.

Council Tax

The Welsh Conservative Party will carefully consider the findings of the Lyons Inquiry. While we are open to the consideration of alternative ways to fund local government expenditure, this must not be used as a way to increase the general burden of taxation.

To be viable, the council tax must be set at a reasonable rate. We would:

- use our investment fund to introduce a £100 council tax discount for pensioner households each year;
- ensure that people are not penalised for improving their properties.

TEAMWORK FOR RURAL WALES

Welsh Conservatives want to see more teamwork in the Welsh Assembly Government to help rural Wales. Rural towns and villages must be supported so that they remain viable communities. Welsh Conservatives would:

- review the delivery of health services in rural areas to ensure the highest level of access to modern services;

- help rural businesses with an expanded business rate relief scheme;
- give greater freedom to planning authorities to provide more land for affordable housing; and introduce some elected members to the boards of the National Park Authorities;
- consult widely with farmers, their unions, and other stakeholders on ways to gain maximum

benefit from the Rural Development Plan;

- allow community partnerships to be formed when an LEA announces its intention to close a school;
- re-establish and enhance the Post Office Development Fund, and invest £4 million in the scheme annually.



SUSTAINABLE COMMUNITIES

Local communities would be empowered under this measure to decide their own expenditure priorities. The Welsh Assembly Government would be required to set out the spending plans for a local authority area. A local authority would then have the power to set its own priorities – those of the local community, established through a consultation procedure – for expenditure. For instance, a local authority may decide to support community post offices. Certain expenditure lines would be exempt – such as acute healthcare and large infrastructure projects – but the majority of public services could be shaped locally.

Community and Town Councils

The Welsh Conservative Party welcomes the fact that One Voice Wales has settled into its role as the representative organisation of Community and Town Councils. We would work with One Voice Wales to ensure that Community and Town Councils play their part in returning public services to local people. Welsh Conservatives would publish a strategy on the development of first tier councils and we would expect more Community and Town Councils to deliver services in co-operation with County Councils. However, such developments would require the necessary funding to follow the services. Our vision for an expanded role for Community and Town Councils is a flexible one and would allow Community and Town Councils to seek to increase their functions at their own request.

Public Services

The Welsh Conservative Party believes that the voluntary and private sectors could play a greater role in the provision of public services. This would provide for more choice in public services and make them more innovative and responsive to local need. Services must be commissioned in a modern and effective manner and the maximum value must be extracted from the Welsh pound.

More regional commissioning needs to be undertaken by groups of local authorities so that fewer looked after children (to take one example) are sent out of county, or even out of Wales altogether, for services. Some services, such as waste recycling and disposal, clearly have to be delivered regionally if the latest technology is to be used to meet sustainable development standards.

Welsh Conservatives would:

- replace the Local Service Boards with powers for local authorities to co-ordinate and prioritise public service expenditure under the Sustainable Communities Measure;
- issue an Annual Report on the performance of public services in Wales;
- promote a mixed economy in public service provision.

Wales and Britain

A strong union



Three hundred years ago the United Kingdom was created when Scotland joined with England and Wales to form a new state. No one can understand the nature of the United Kingdom unless they realise that it is a political partnership between the Home Nations. Together Wales, England, Scotland and Northern Ireland have combined to create one of the world's most successful states. Britain stood firm in 1940 to give Europe the chance to be liberated in 1945. Welsh Conservatives are proud of Wales and proud of Britain. We firmly believe both will endure and that our greatest achievements lie ahead of us and not in the past.

Ten years ago the people of Wales narrowly voted for devolution. Since then, with devolution in practice in Wales and Scotland and potentially in Northern Ireland, more and more people believe devolution is necessary for a strong Britain. Welsh Conservatives believe this too, despite our fears in 1997. We freely acknowledge that devolution has not weakened Britain. Our task now is to use devolution imaginatively to make Britain stronger.

Labour has undermined the devolution settlement that the people of Wales voted for in 1997. Cynically, and despite the condemnation of the independent Electoral Commission, Labour manipulated the Assembly's election rules for partisan gain. And Labour has sought to make the Assembly a law-making body without the express consent of the Welsh electorate. The Government of Wales Act 2006 is badly flawed, but Welsh Conservatives will work within its provisions for the sake of the people of Wales.

A Welsh Conservative government would:

- promote the establishment of a Devolution Forum between the devolved Home Nations and Westminster to allow for the exchange of ideas between Governments in the different parts of the United Kingdom;

- establish procedures to encourage public participation in the work of the National Assembly and the Welsh Assembly government. Mechanisms would include a strengthened petitions process and the use of peoples' juries to assist policy development;
- seek to restore the reputation of Wales by abolishing the Labour Party's much condemned manipulation of the Assembly's election rules.

Welsh Conservatives believe that in a number of areas the needs of Wales require the further development of devolution. Welsh Conservatives would:

- seek to establish St. David's Day as a national holiday;
- introduce a Welsh symbol on car number plates;
- ensure that a separate Welsh option appears on census forms together with a question on the use of Welsh;
- petition the Queen to establish a Welsh order of chivalry.

WELSH CONSERVATIVES – SERVING THE PEOPLE

Welsh Conservatives acknowledge the fact that many voters feel frustrated by traditional politics. Sadly, some even feel cynical and think that politicians are merely 'in it for themselves'. Welsh Conservatives believe that a new contract is needed between AMs and the voters to inspire new

confidence and higher standards in public life. We would:

- work harder by extending the hours during which the Assembly conducts official business;
- strengthen the Assembly's petitions process and use 'peoples' juries' to help develop

policy;

- publish an annual report on the work of the Welsh Conservative Group in the National Assembly;
 - publish information on the expenses claimed by Welsh Conservative AMs.
-